

PORTRAIT OF A FAMILY: Shah Rukh and wife Gauri pose with his wax statue at Paris's Musee Grevin



SHAH RUKH'S Rs 100-crore fairytale seaside mansion, his finest accomplishment, is built entirely with his blood and sweat. He is not always being ironic when he calls it the most famous address in India.

as an outsider mirroring the rise of young, aspirational India.

It is a compelling story, repeated in at least two biographies and a two-part documentary, making him the most analysed among his contemporaries. It's a story that makes comparisons with the past a tad obsolete. As film scholar Nasreen Munni Kabir says: "It's a whole new world. You can't compare the stardom of Dilip Kumar or even Amitabh Bachchan with the 24-hour celebrity-guzzling machine that exists today."

Shah Rukh's storytelling is bout others as well—friends and rivals alike—told mercilessly with dead-on mimicry, to a posse

of pals stretching from recent entrant Arjun Rampal to the old faithful Karan Johar. The home is ruled by a velvet glove, Gauri's perma party gloss masking an utterly sensible woman who is as likely to scream at her son for not doing his homework as she is to twit her husband for putting his shoes on the table.

"Mehmannawazi" is intrinsic to her and evident even in the way her husband treats his team, hosting a party for them after every match, unmindful of whether they win or lose. "It is evident in the way", says friend Farah Khan, "he will drive to town after a long day to make sure he attends the wedding of a Red Chillies staffer."

"My father used to tell me, be gracious in victory and graceful in defeat," says Shah Rukh, though it doesn't stop him from getting into cheeky chatback contests, with an array of notables such as Amar Singh and Akshay Kumar.

Where will it all end? In an IPO, so that he can build his new dream, which could be a studio or a stadium? He doesn't rule it out, looking at friends Dhoot and Mehta in the room. "If these guys say so..." he trails off. Will he be able to sustain a movie career that is as versatile as his interests? If it worries him, he doesn't show it. "Because you know what, all that I know is that when I wake up at 10, put my make-up on, and go to work, I am still as jittery about what I'm doing as I was 20 years ago," he says. That anxiety to excel is inscribed in his DNA. And it is one that matches a youthful India that worships success.

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is the number of films starring him in the top five Hindi films at the US box office. The total US revenue of his top four films is \$12.7 m.